5 Reflexive Pronouns

Revision

In Book 4, you have learnt that *pronouns* are words that are often used in place of nouns which have already been mentioned or are already known. You have also looked at one class of pronouns—*personal pronouns* like *I, you, he, she, it* and their different forms.

Reflexive Pronouns

We shall now look at another group of pronouns that are formed by adding the suffix *-self* (singular) or *-selves* (plural) to some of the different forms of the personal pronouns. These pronouns are known as ***reflexive pronouns***.

A table of the different forms of these pronouns is given below:

Person	Gender and Number	Form of the Reflexive Pronoun
First person	All genders; singular	*myself*
	All genders; plural	*ourselves*
Second person	All genders; singular	*yourself*
	All genders; plural	*yourselves*
Third person	Masculine; singular	*himself*
	Feminine; singular	*herself*
	Common; singular	*himself* / *herself* / *itself* (as applicable)
	Neuter; singular	*itself*
	All genders; plural	*themselves*

Note that though in the case of the second person personal pronoun, the same form *you* is used to refer to one or more than one person, in the case of the second person reflexive pronoun, *yourself* is the singular form and *yourselves* the plural form.

Uses of Reflexive Pronouns

1. Reflexive pronouns are used for emphasis.
   When a reflexive pronoun is used for emphasis, it is also known as an ***emphatic*** or ***emphasizing pronoun***.
   (a) Gopalan cooked all the dishes himself.
   (b) We ourselves saw a tiger fighting with an elephant.
   (c) Vikram went to Delhi himself.

   In *(a)*, the fact that *Gopalan,* and not somebody else, cooked the dishes is emphasized.

   In *(b)*, the fact that *we* saw something with our *own* eyes is emphasized: it is not that we are merely reporting what we have heard from somebody or what somebody else saw.

   Though the reflexive pronoun used for emphasis is usually placed after the subject, it can be placed, as in *(a)*, after the object of a transitive verb or, as in *(c)*, after an intransitive verb + preposition + noun (object of a preposition: *Delhi* is the object of the preposition *to*).

   Note that as used in *(a)*, *(b)* and *(c)*, the reflexive pronouns can be omitted without changing the meaning of the sentences.

   When a reflexive pronoun is used to emphasize a noun other than the subject, it is placed immediately after that noun.

   (d) Alice met the Queen herself.

   The sentence emphasizes the fact that Alice met the Queen and not somebody else. So, *herself* comes immediately after *Queen*.

2. Reflexive pronouns are also used to emphasize that somebody does, did or will do something alone, or without any help or interference from anyone else.

   Note the use of the preposition *by* in the following examples:

   (e) The old man lived in that house all ***by*** *himself.* (= alone)

   (f) I solved the puzzle ***by*** *myself.* (= without the help of anybody else)

   (g) The little girl was carrying the heavy box all ***by*** *herself.* (without any help)

3. Reflexive pronouns are used after verbs with prepositions to make it clear which person or thing we are talking about:

   (h) Ram is angry ***with*** *himself. (= Ram)*

   (i) Ram is angry ***with*** *him. (= somebody other than Ram)*

   (j) Ranjan was talking ***to*** *him. (= somebody other than Ranjan)*

   (k) Ranjan was talking ***to*** *himself. (= Ranjan)*

   When it is clear which person we are talking about, a reflexive pronoun is *not* used.

   (l) Hotels do not permit guests to keep their pets with them in their rooms.

   Note that we do not use *themselves* here, for it is clear that *them* cannot refer to anybody else but the *guests* themselves.

4. Reflexive pronouns are not usually used in the case of actions that people normally do to themselves, like washing, dressing, etc.

   We do not usually say: *I washed and dressed myself.*

   We say: *I washed and dressed.*

   However, if somebody does something that he/she/it is not normally expected to do, the reflexive may be used to express surprise or some such feeling.

   (m) We saw that the ***child*** *could bathe and dress itself.*

   Normally, a child is bathed and dressed by somebody else. The use of the reflexive *itself* expresses surprise that the child could do all this without anybody's help.

   (n) The ***dog*** *itself opened the door and chased the postman down the road!*

   Opening a door is a difficult thing for a dog to do, but this dog did it!

   Obviously, the speaker, as well as the postman, was surprised.

5. Reflexive pronouns are used when the object, direct or indirect, of a verb is the same person or thing as the subject of the verb:

(o) *The captain blamed himself for losing the match.*

(p) *You must control yourself and stop shouting at others.*

(q) *Rita bought herself a new dress for the festival.*

In *(o)*, the subject *captain* did something to *himself*. The action denoted by the verb—*blamed*—affected the subject himself. So, *himself* is the object of the verb *blamed*.

Similarly in *(p)*, the subject and the object refer to the same person: *yourself* is the object of the verb *control*.

In *(q)*, we have two objects:

Q: Rita bought *what*? A: *(a new) dress*

Q: Rita bought *whom* a dress? A: *herself*

So, the verb *bought* has two objects: (i) *dress* (direct object) and (ii) *herself* (indirect object).

In Chapter 4, you were told that the object, *direct* or *indirect*, of a verb must refer to a person or thing that is different from the subject itself. We now find that in some cases, the object and subject can be the same person or thing. This is, therefore, an exception to the rule mentioned. For this reason, when a verb takes a reflexive pronoun as its object, we say that the verb has been used *reflexively*, rather than saying that it is a *transitive* verb, and we call the object a *reflexive object*.

Note that a reflexive pronoun is not used when the subject and object are different persons or things. This is a common error. Avoid it.

We do not say:	*John helped myself.*	✗
We say:	*John helped me.*	✓
We do not say:	*I shall write a letter to yourself.*	✗
We say:	*I shall write a letter to you.*	✓

Fill in the blanks with appropriate reflexive pronouns:

1. Uncle Podger always blamed others, but never ..... for the mistakes he made.
2. Dipti liked the room ..... , but not the furniture in it.
3. The girl could not control ..... and burst out laughing.
4. A robot can do many things by ..... .
5. The dog saw ..... in the mirror and started barking.

6. Jayant forced ..... to swallow the bitter medicine.
7. The brother was turned into a bird and the seven beautiful sisters were ..... turned into seven stars.
8. The patient tried to get out of his bed by ..... and fell down.
9. John was afraid to spend the night in the empty house all by ..... .
10. The animals saved ..... from the fire by jumping into the river.
11. The man said that he ..... had seen the tiger going into the cave.
12. It is said that God helps those who help ..... .

13. 'You must learn to behave ..... ,' the Principal told Usha.
14. We have never met Mr Singh ..... , but we would like to give him the letter ..... .
15. The guests were requested to help ..... to the food placed on the table.